warm in the cold air. They were told that these yogis gathered in this manner every year, begging for alms. Akbar, his courtiers, and the Jesuits crossed the Ravi to speak with the yogis, the noblemen in their silks, jewels, and soft woollen shawls presenting a glittering contrast to the yogis in their drab rags. After spending a few days in companionable discussions, the yogis ‘scattered and left as quickly as they had come’.

The Jesuits were thoroughly confounded by what Akbar was, or considered himself to be. ‘[O]ne does not know for certain what law he follows. For though he is certainly not a Mahometan, as his actions show plainly enough, and though he seems to incline more to the superstitions of the Pagans, Gentiles (Hindus) being more welcome at his court than Mahometans, he cannot be called an Ethnique (Hindu), for he adores and recognises the true God, the maker of heaven and earth, and yet, at the same time, he worships the sun.’ They had noticed, of course, that Akbar began his day by worshipping the sun, repeating ‘as many as a thousand and fifty names’ of the sun, using a japmala made of precious stones.

This very personal search of the Padshah’s for a divine truth above all the sectarian differences that convulsed his empire would perplex the Jesuits, who saw in this a sign of weakness or, even more worryingly, delusion. For they noted that ‘it is more or less certain that he has a strong desire to be looked upon, and esteemed as a God, or some great Prophet’. Unlike the rigid protocol at court, they said, as had others before them, that Akbar allowed throngs of lesser folk to approach him, many of whom believed that the Padshah could perform miracles, ‘healing the sick with the water with which he washes his feet’. Young women ‘pay vows to him to get their children cured, or that they may have children. And if these things come to pass, they bring him offerings as to a saint, which, though they may be of little worth, are willingly received and highly valued by him.’ The Jesuits were possibly unaware of the ideas of sacred kingship in which the ruler was a legitimate source of divine power—in neighbouring Persia, kings had sought to add heft to their claims by taking on semi-divine and Sufi-tinged auras.

Perhaps the Jesuits would have found some explanation for Akbar’s enthusiastic adoption of Christian, Jain, and Hindu practices had they read his letter of advice to Shah Abbas II of Persia the year before. ‘It must be considered that the Divine mercy attaches itself to every form of creed,’ wrote Akbar, ‘and supreme exertions must be made to bring oneself into the